HUDSON BEAT



NUTCRACKER LISTENING UNIT

Tchaikovsky 1892 · story · 6 listening maps · instrument spotting · quiz with key

GRADES 2–6 · 6 MOVEMENTS · 17 PAGES

TEACHER NOTES

Nutcracker Listening Unit · Tchaikovsky, 1892 · grades 2–6

WHAT IT IS

A short unit that takes students through Tchaikovsky's ballet *The Nutcracker* by listening. They read the story, then listen to six famous pieces with a listening map and response page for each, spot instruments, take a quiz and write a review. Every answer comes with a key.

BEFORE YOU START: CHOOSE A RECORDING

No audio is included. Use any recording you have the right to play in class: a school or library music service, your own collection, or an orchestral recording in the public domain. The music is by Tchaikovsky (1840–1893) and is long out of copyright, but many recordings are not, so check the recording you use. Listen to it yourself first, and find the movements by title.

HOW EACH LISTENING PAGE WORKS

1. Read the "About this music" box together.
2. Play the movement once while students just listen.
3. Play it again while they mark the map. Say "next" about every 15 seconds so the boxes keep pace with the music.
4. Play it a third time if you like. Students circle what they heard and write: grades 2–3 finish a sentence, grades 4–6 write three.

GRADE LEVELS

Grades 2–3 use the sentence starters; grades 4–6 write full sentences with the toolkit words. Read the quiz aloud to grade 2.

GOOD TO KNOW

- The story is set at a Christmas Eve party, as in the original. The unit is about music and ballet, with no religious teaching, and works in any winter program.
- Productions differ; the story here is one common version. Prints well in black and white.

WHAT'S INSIDE

PART	PAGES	USE
Story and toolkit	3–5	read the story, check it, learn the music words
Listening maps	6–11	6 movements: map, circle, describe
Instrument spotting	12–13	gallery and chart
Quiz and key	14–15	16-point quiz and all answers
Review	16	favorite movement, drawing and letter
Terms of use	17	license and credits

THE SIX MOVEMENTS

#	TITLE	IN THE STORY
1	March	Guests arrive at the party
2	Waltz of the Snowflakes	Snowflakes dance in the forest
3	Trepak (Russian Dance)	Treats from around the world dance
4	Dance of the Reed Flutes	Treats from around the world dance
5	Waltz of the Flowers	Flowers waltz in the Kingdom of Sweets
6	Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy	The Sugar Plum Fairy dances

PACING

DAY	PLAN	TIME
1	Read the story, then the story check	25–30 min
2	Toolkit, then Movements 1 and 2	35–40 min
3	Movements 3 and 4	30 min
4	Movements 5 and 6	30 min
5	Instrument gallery and spotting chart	30 min
6	Quiz, then review	35 min

STANDARDS

Supports responding to music: selecting and describing what students hear (MU:Re7.1, MU:Re7.2) and connecting music to its history and culture (MU:Cn11.0), National Core Arts Standards, Music.

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THE NUTCRACKER STORY

Meet the ballet · the story in six scenes

READ

Story summary

The composer Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky (1840–1893) was a Russian composer. He also wrote the ballets *Swan Lake* and *The Sleeping Beauty*.

The ballet The Nutcracker was first performed on December 18, 1892, at the Mariinsky Theatre in St. Petersburg, Russia. The choreography was by Lev Ivanov, from plans by Marius Petipa.

The story It comes from a tale by E. T. A. Hoffmann (1816), retold by Alexandre Dumas in 1844.

A ballet A ballet tells a story with dance and music, but no talking. The orchestra plays all the music. Tchaikovsky also made a concert suite of eight pieces from it that is played without dancers.

Hearing it You will hear six pieces (movements). Each one matches a part of the story.

1 ACT I · THE PARTY

On Christmas Eve, Clara and her brother Fritz welcome guests. Her godfather Drosselmeyer, a toymaker, brings gifts, including a nutcracker doll shaped like a soldier. **(Movement 1, March)**

2 ACT I · MIDNIGHT

Fritz breaks the nutcracker, and Clara tucks it in. At midnight the Christmas tree grows tall and mice creep in. The Nutcracker leads the toy soldiers against the Mouse King. Clara throws her slipper, and the Nutcracker wins and turns into a prince.

3 ACT I · THE SNOWY FOREST

The Prince takes Clara through a forest where snowflakes dance. **(Movement 2, Waltz of the Snowflakes)**

4 ACT II · THE KINGDOM OF SWEETS

They arrive in a land of sweets ruled by the Sugar Plum Fairy. She welcomes them and orders dances to be shown for Clara. **(Movement 3, Trepak; Movement 4, Reed Flutes)**

5 ACT II · THE FLOWERS AND THE FAIRY

The flowers dance a waltz. The Sugar Plum Fairy and the Prince dance. **(Movement 5, Waltz of the Flowers; Movement 6, Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy)**

6 ACT II · GOODBYE

Clara says goodbye to her new friends. In many versions she wakes up at home, wondering if it was a dream.

Every company tells the story a little differently: names, scenes and endings change from one production to the next. This is one common version.

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NUTCRACKER STORY CHECK

Story check

STORY

Show what you know

Name _____ Date _____

Use the story on page 3 to help you.

A · PUT THE STORY IN ORDER

Write 1 to 6 in the box (1 is first).

A	They reach the Kingdom of Sweets, where the Sugar Plum Fairy welcomes them.	☐
B	At the Christmas Eve party, Clara's godfather Drosselmeyer gives her a nutcracker doll.	☐
C	The flowers waltz, and the Sugar Plum Fairy and the Prince dance. Clara says goodbye.	☐
D	The Nutcracker becomes a prince and takes Clara through a snowy forest where snowflakes dance.	☐
E	Dances from around the world are performed for Clara, such as the Russian dance and the Reed Flutes.	☐
F	At midnight the tree grows tall, and the Nutcracker leads the toy soldiers against the Mouse King and his mice.	☐

B · WHO IS WHO?

Write the letter of the matching description.

Clara _____

Drosselmeyer _____

Mouse King _____

Sugar Plum Fairy _____

A The leader of the mice who attack at midnight.

B The girl who receives the nutcracker and travels with it.

C The ruler of the Kingdom of Sweets.

D The godfather who makes and brings the nutcracker.

C · DRAW AND TELL

Draw your favorite scene and write one sentence about it.

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LISTENING TOOLKIT

Words for describing music

These are the words you will use to describe music. Keep this page next to you while you listen.

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS	TRY SAYING IT
Tempo	How fast or slow the beat is. *adagio* = slow, *moderato* = medium, *allegro* = fast.	"The tempo is fast."
Dynamics	How loud or soft. *piano* (p) = soft, *forte* (f) = loud. *Crescendo* = gets louder, *decrescendo* = gets softer.	"It starts soft and gets louder."
Beat	The steady pulse you can tap.	"I can tap the beat."
Meter	How the beats group: in 2s (march or gallop), in 3s (waltz) or in 4s.	"It feels like ONE-two-three."
Pitch	How high or low a sound is.	"The tune goes up high."
Timbre	The color of a sound: which instrument or voice you hear.	"It sounds like tiny bells."
Mood	The feeling the music gives you.	"It sounds magical."

THE FOUR FAMILIES OF THE ORCHESTRA

FAMILY	HOW THE SOUND IS MADE	EXAMPLES IN THIS UNIT
Strings	Bowed or plucked strings	violin, harp
Woodwinds	Blowing air across or through a pipe or reed	flute, bass clarinet
Brass	Buzzing lips into a metal tube	trumpet, French horn
Percussion	Hitting, shaking or scraping. A celesta has keys that strike metal bars.	celesta

HOW TO LISTEN: THREE TIMES

1 Just listen. Close your eyes. Do not write yet.

2 Listen with your listening map. Mark as you go.

3 Circle what you heard and tell about it.

BE A POLITE AUDIENCE

- Quiet voices and bodies so everyone can hear.
- There are no wrong feelings about music. Say why you feel that way.

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MARCH

Act I · the party arrives · movement 1 of 6

MOVEMENT 1

Listening map

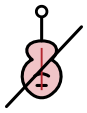
Name _____ Date _____

ABOUT THIS MUSIC

- Tchaikovsky wrote it for the guests arriving at the holiday party.
- It has a steady beat in groups of 4 (4/4), so you can march to it.
- Listen for bright trumpets and the string section.

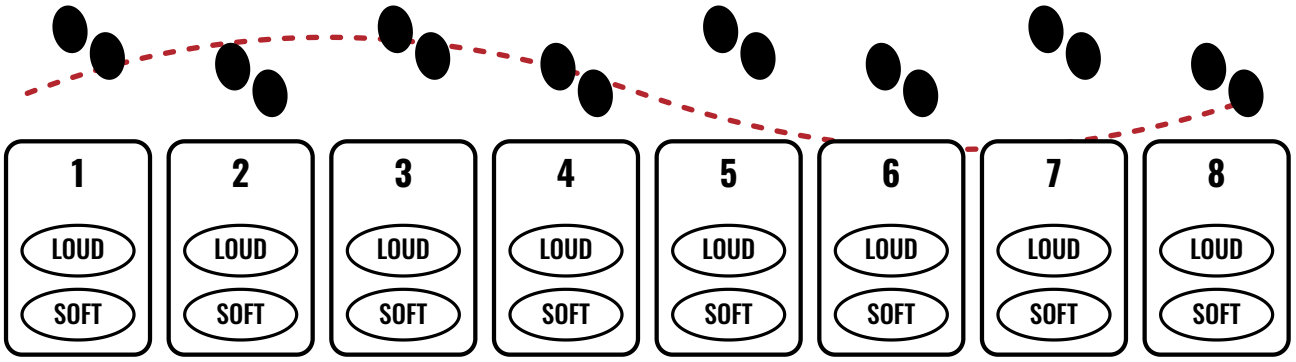


Trumpet



Violin

LISTENING MAP · Step along the path. In each box circle **LOUD** or **SOFT** for what you hear in that part.



Teacher: say "next" about every 15 seconds (stop at box 8, or start over if the music is longer).

CIRCLE WHAT YOU HEAR

Tempo SLOW · adagio | MEDIUM · moderato | FAST · allegro

Dynamics LOUD | SOFT | GETS LOUDER | GETS SOFTER | BOTH

Mood PROUD | EXCITED | HAPPY | GRAND | PLAYFUL | CALM

Sounds VIOLIN | HARP | FLUTE | BASS CLARINET | TRUMPET | FRENCH HORN | CELESTA | CHILDREN'S VOICES

TELL ABOUT IT ·

Grades 2–3: "This music sounds like _____ because _____." **Grades 4–6:** write 3 sentences using music words (tempo, dynamics, instruments, mood).

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WALTZ OF THE SNOWFLAKES

End of Act I · the snowy forest · movement 2 of 6

MOVEMENT 2

Listening map

Name _____ Date _____

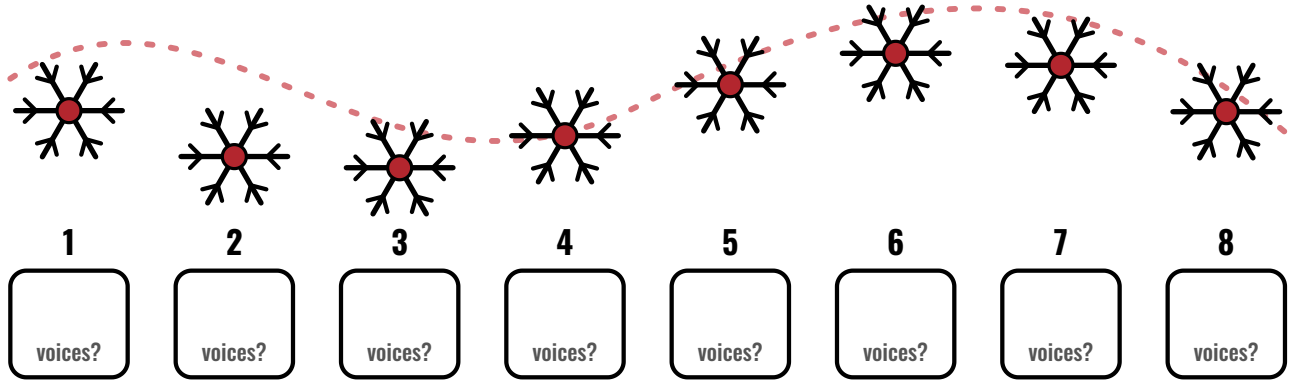
ABOUT THIS MUSIC

- Clara and the Nutcracker Prince travel through a snowy forest where snowflakes dance.
- In the ballet, a chorus of children sings with no words, joining the orchestra.
- The music swirls and whirls like falling snow.



Children's voices Violin

LISTENING MAP · Follow the dotted path from flake to flake. Write a **V** in the box when you hear voices.



Teacher: say "next" about every 15 seconds (stop at box 8, or start over if the music is longer).

CIRCLE WHAT YOU HEAR

Tempo SLOW · adagio | MEDIUM · moderato | FAST · allegro

Dynamics LOUD | SOFT | GETS LOUDER | GETS SOFTER | BOTH

Mood PEACEFUL | MAGICAL | ICY | EXCITED | SLEEPY | THOUGHTFUL

Sounds VIOLIN | HARP | FLUTE | BASS CLARINET | TRUMPET | FRENCH HORN | CELESTA | CHILDREN'S VOICES

TELL ABOUT IT ·

Grades 2–3: "This music sounds like _____ because _____." **Grades 4–6:** write 3 sentences using music words (tempo, dynamics, instruments, mood).

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TREPAK (RUSSIAN DANCE)

Act II · treats dance for Clara · movement 3 of 6

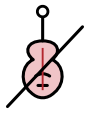
MOVEMENT 3

Listening map

Name _____ Date _____

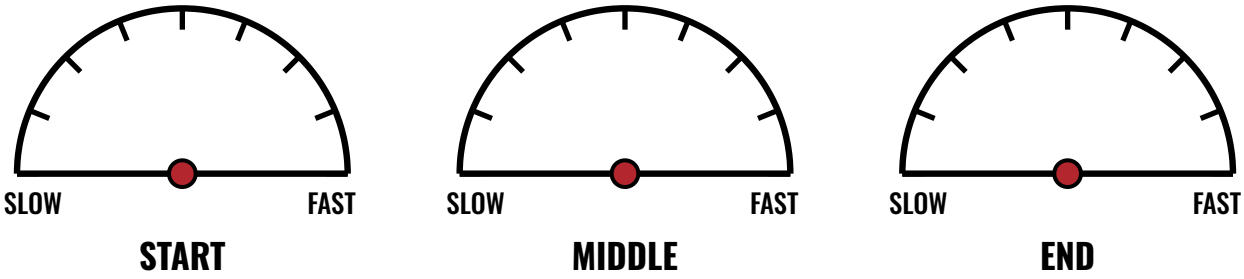
ABOUT THIS MUSIC

- A trepak is a fast folk dance from Russia. Dancers leap and kick.
- It is in groups of 2 beats (2/4), like a gallop: ONE-two, ONE-two.
- It starts fast and keeps speeding up to a big finish.



Violin

LISTENING MAP · Draw the needle where the speed is at the **start**, the **middle** and the **end**.



Teacher: say “next” about every 15 seconds (stop at box 8, or start over if the music is longer).

CIRCLE WHAT YOU HEAR

Tempo SLOW · adagio | MEDIUM · moderato | FAST · allegro

Dynamics LOUD | SOFT | GETS LOUDER | GETS SOFTER | BOTH

Mood EXCITED | PLAYFUL | WILD | PROUD | HAPPY | CALM

Sounds VIOLIN | HARP | FLUTE | BASS CLARINET | TRUMPET | FRENCH HORN | CELESTA | CHILDREN'S VOICES

TELL ABOUT IT ·

Grades 2–3: “This music sounds like _____ because _____.” **Grades 4–6:** write 3 sentences using music words (tempo, dynamics, instruments, mood).

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DANCE OF THE REED FLUTES

Act II · treats dance for Clara · movement 4 of 6

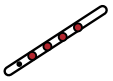
MOVEMENT 4

Listening map

Name _____ Date _____

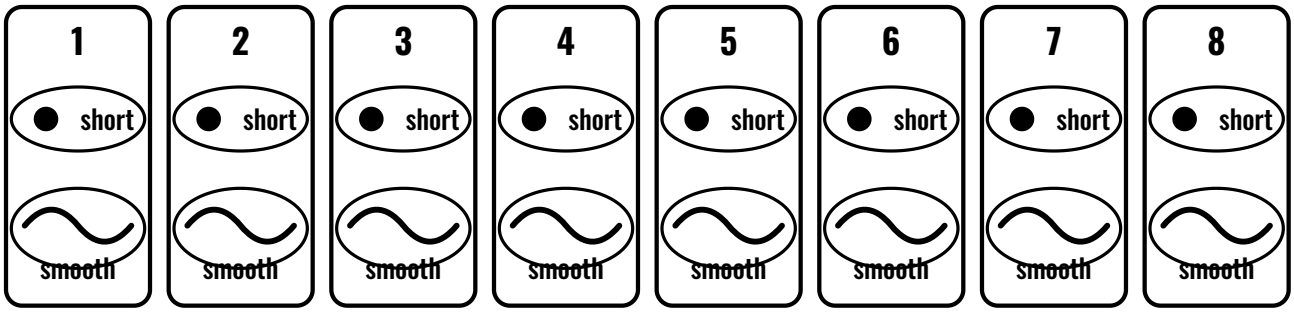
ABOUT THIS MUSIC

- Another dance for Clara in the Kingdom of Sweets. Its French name is Mirlitons.
- Three flutes play the light, sweet tune together.
- The short, light notes make it sound tiny and dainty.



Flute

LISTENING MAP · In each box circle **short** (dots) or **smooth** (a wavy line). How many flutes? _____



Teacher: say "next" about every 15 seconds (stop at box 8, or start over if the music is longer).

CIRCLE WHAT YOU HEAR

Tempo SLOW · adagio | MEDIUM · moderato | FAST · allegro

Dynamics LOUD | SOFT | GETS LOUDER | GETS SOFTER | BOTH

Mood PLAYFUL | DAINTY | HAPPY | CALM | COZY | SLEEPY

Sounds VIOLIN | HARP | FLUTE | BASS CLARINET | TRUMPET | FRENCH HORN | CELESTA | CHILDREN'S VOICES

TELL ABOUT IT ·

Grades 2–3: "This music sounds like _____ because _____." **Grades 4–6:** write 3 sentences using music words (tempo, dynamics, instruments, mood).

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WALTZ OF THE FLOWERS

Act II · the flowers dance · movement 5 of 6

MOVEMENT 5

Listening map

Name _____ Date _____

ABOUT THIS MUSIC

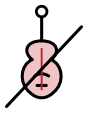
- The flowers dance a grand waltz for Clara and the Prince.
- A harp plays a long, sweeping flourish before the waltz begins.
- A waltz has 3 beats in each group (3/4): ONE-two-three.



Harp

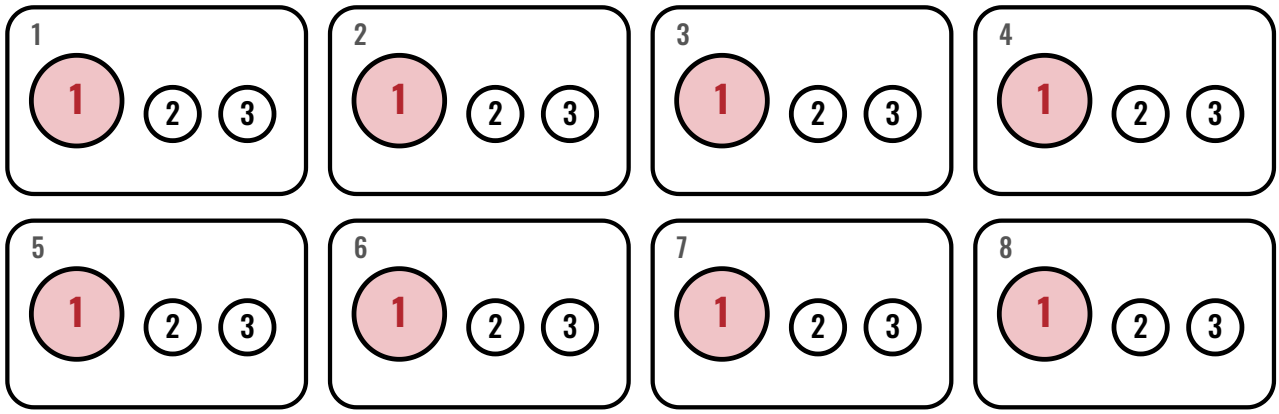


French horn



Violin

LISTENING MAP · First, wiggle a line up when the **harp** plays. Then tap **1**-2-3 in each flower group. Put a star where the tune begins.



Teacher: say “next” about every 15 seconds (stop at box 8, or start over if the music is longer).

CIRCLE WHAT YOU HEAR

Tempo SLOW · adagio | MEDIUM · moderato | FAST · allegro

Dynamics LOUD | SOFT | GETS LOUDER | GETS SOFTER | BOTH

Mood GRAND | GRACEFUL | HAPPY | EXCITED | PEACEFUL | PROUD

Sounds VIOLIN | HARP | FLUTE | BASS CLARINET | TRUMPET | FRENCH HORN | CELESTA | CHILDREN'S VOICES

TELL ABOUT IT ·

Grades 2–3: “This music sounds like _____ because _____.” **Grades 4–6:** write 3 sentences using music words (tempo, dynamics, instruments, mood).

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DANCE OF THE SUGAR PLUM FAIRY

Act II · the Fairy dances · movement 6 of 6

MOVEMENT 6

Listening map

Name _____ Date _____

ABOUT THIS MUSIC

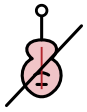
- The Sugar Plum Fairy rules the Kingdom of Sweets.
- Tchaikovsky heard a new instrument, the celesta, in Paris and wanted it for this dance.
- The celesta sparkles on top while a bass clarinet plays low and strings pluck.



Celesta

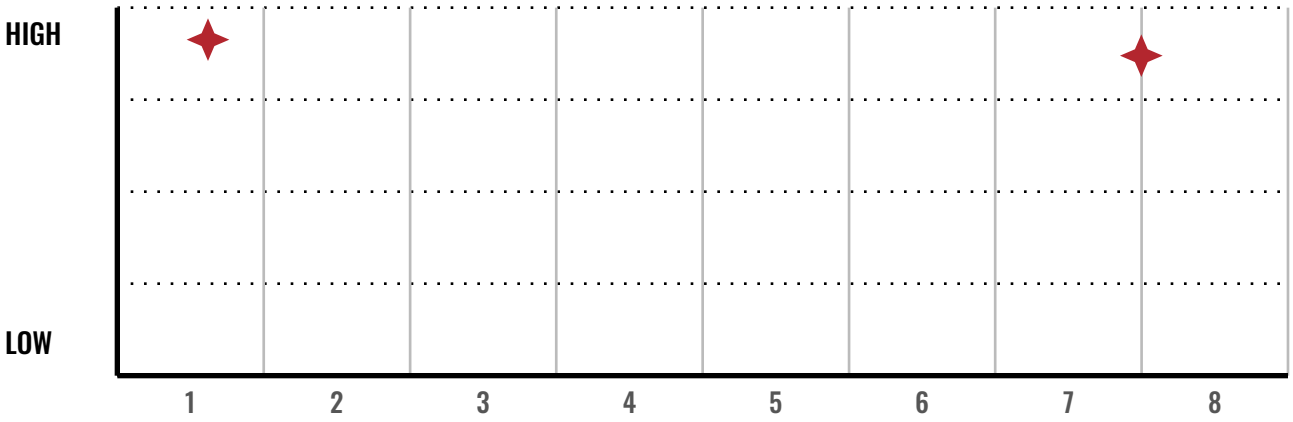


Bass clarinet



Violin

LISTENING MAP · Draw the tune as a line: up when the notes go higher, down when lower. Put an **S** by the sparkly sound and an **L** by a low sound.



Teacher: say "next" about every 15 seconds (stop at box 8, or start over if the music is longer).

CIRCLE WHAT YOU HEAR

Tempo SLOW · adagio | MEDIUM · moderato | FAST · allegro

Dynamics LOUD | SOFT | GETS LOUDER | GETS SOFTER | BOTH

Mood MAGICAL | DAINTY | PEACEFUL | SLEEPY | THOUGHTFUL | COZY

Sounds VIOLIN | HARP | FLUTE | BASS CLARINET | TRUMPET | FRENCH HORN | CELESTA | CHILDREN'S VOICES

TELL ABOUT IT ·

Grades 2–3: "This music sounds like _____ because _____." **Grades 4–6:** write 3 sentences using music words (tempo, dynamics, instruments, mood).

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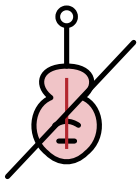
INSTRUMENT GALLERY

The orchestra instruments you will hear

LOOK

Instrument gallery

Meet the eight sounds you will hunt for. Next, use the spotting chart on page 13.



VIOLIN

STRINGS

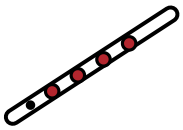
Bowed strings. The violin section is the heart of the orchestra.



HARP

STRINGS

Plucked strings. Sweeping glides are called glissandos.



FLUTE

WOODWINDS

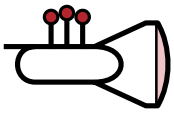
A high woodwind you blow across. Light and bird-like.



BASS CLARINET

WOODWINDS

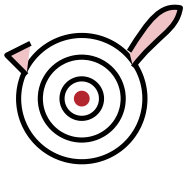
A very low woodwind with a curved metal bell.



TRUMPET

BRASS

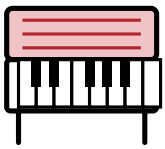
Bright, bold brass. Often plays calls and fanfares.



FRENCH HORN

BRASS

A round, warm brass sound from a coiled tube.



CELESTA

KEYBOARD PERCUSSION

A keyboard that strikes metal bars. Sounds like tiny bells.



CHILDREN'S VOICES

VOICES

Singers. In the ballet, children sing without words.

Did you know? Tchaikovsky heard the celesta in Paris and brought one to Russia for The Nutcracker. Most listeners had never heard it before 1892. It is played with a keyboard, but a hammer strikes a metal bar inside, so it sounds like a tiny bell.

DRAW IT

Pick your favorite instrument above. Draw it in the box and write one word that describes its sound.

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INSTRUMENT SPOTTING

Which instruments do you hear?

SPOT

Spotting chart

Name _____ Date _____

Listen to each movement again. Put an **X** under every instrument you can hear **clearly**. Many instruments play, so look for the ones that stand out.

MOVEMENT	VIOLIN	HARP	FLUTE	BASS CLARINET	TRUMPET	FRENCH HORN	CELESTA	CHILDREN'S VOICES
1 · March								
2 · Waltz of the Snowflakes								
3 · Trepak (Russian Dance)								
4 · Dance of the Reed Flutes								
5 · Waltz of the Flowers								
6 · Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy								

WHICH WAS EASIEST TO HEAR? WHY?

_____

_____

_____

INSTRUMENT FAMILIES

Write each instrument under its family.

Strings

Woodwinds

Brass

Percussion

Children's voices are not in an instrument family. Write them in the margin.

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NUTCRACKER QUIZ

16 questions · 20 minutes

QUIZ

16 points

Name _____ Date _____

A · MATCH EACH CLUE TO A MOVEMENT Write the movement number in the blank.

1 March · **2** Waltz of the Snowflakes · **3** Trepak (Russian Dance) · **4** Dance of the Reed Flutes · **5** Waltz of the Flowers · **6** Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy

1. ____ A waltz that opens with a harp flourish and feels like ONE-two-three

2. ____ A very fast Russian folk dance that keeps speeding up

3. ____ Guests arrive at the party; bright trumpets and a steady 4-beat march

4. ____ The sparkling celesta plays the tune, like a music box

5. ____ Dancing snowflakes; children's voices (with no words) join the orchestra

6. ____ Three flutes play a light, dainty tune together

B · CIRCLE THE BEST ANSWER

7. Who composed The Nutcracker?
A Mozart **B** Tchaikovsky **C** Beethoven

8. The ballet was first performed in the year
A 1792 **B** 1992 **C** 1892

9. Which instrument plays the tune in the Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy?
A Celesta **B** Trumpet **C** Trombone

10. How many beats are in each group of a waltz?
A 2 **B** 4 **C** 3

11. Which dance speeds up as it goes on?
A Waltz of the Flowers **B** Trepak **C** Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy

12. The flute belongs to which instrument family?
A Brass **B** Strings **C** Woodwinds

C · TRUE OR FALSE Circle one.

13. TRUE FALSE The Nutcracker is a ballet that tells its story with music and dance.

14. TRUE FALSE The harp is a brass instrument.

15. TRUE FALSE The Trepak is a slow, quiet dance.

16. TRUE FALSE Tchaikovsky was a composer from Russia.

Score: _____ / 16

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ANSWER KEY

Answer key · story check, spotting chart and quiz

ANSWER KEY

Teacher copy

STORY CHECK (PAGE 4)

A · Story order, first to last	**Cards B F D A E C**
B · Who is who	Clara: **B** · Drosselmeyer: **D** · Mouse King: **A** · Sugar Plum Fairy: **C**

Part A: card letters in story order, so card B is 1 and card C is 6. Part C is open: accept any scene with one sentence.

INSTRUMENT SPOTTING (PAGE 13)

MOVEMENT	INSTRUMENTS THAT STAND OUT
1 · March	**Violin, Trumpet**
2 · Waltz of the Snowflakes	**Violin, Children's voices**
3 · Trepak (Russian Dance)	**Violin**
4 · Dance of the Reed Flutes	**Flute**
5 · Waltz of the Flowers	**Violin, Harp, French horn**
6 · Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy	**Violin, Bass clarinet, Celesta**

Other instruments also play. Accept any you can truly hear, and listen once yourself first. Families: Strings = violin, harp · Woodwinds = flute, bass clarinet · Brass = trumpet, French horn · Percussion = celesta.

QUIZ (PAGE 14) · 16 POINTS

A · Clue number: movement	1: **5** · 2: **3** · 3: **1** · 4: **6** · 5: **2** · 6: **4**
B · Multiple choice	7: **B** · 8: **C** · 9: **A** · 10: **C** · 11: **B** · 12: **C**
C · True / false	13: **TRUE** · 14: **FALSE** · 15: **FALSE** · 16: **TRUE**

Scoring: 1 point each. 14–16 = excellent listener, 11–13 = good, 8–10 = keep listening, 0–7 = review the story and the toolkit.

MOVEMENT FACTS

MOVEMENT	METER IN THE MUSIC
1 · March	**4/4**
2 · Waltz of the Snowflakes	**not asked**
3 · Trepak (Russian Dance)	**2/4**
4 · Dance of the Reed Flutes	**not asked**
5 · Waltz of the Flowers	**3/4**
6 · Dance of the Sugar Plum Fairy	**not asked**

LISTENING MAPS (ANSWERS VARY)

Trepak: the needle moves toward FAST by the end. **Reed Flutes:** three flutes. **Sugar Plum Fairy:** the celesta is the sparkly high sound, the bass clarinet the low one. **Flowers:** the harp plays first; the tune begins after it. **March:** mark loud and soft as you hear them, and accept anything the class can support. **Snowflakes:** voices join the orchestra partway through. Maps and responses are about careful listening, so give credit for reasons.

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MY NUTCRACKER REVIEW

Your turn to be the critic

Name _____ Date _____

You have heard six pieces from the ballet. Now be the critic.

MY FAVORITE MOVEMENT Circle one.

1 · MARCH | 2 · WALTZ OF THE SNOWFLAKES | 3 · TREPAK (RUSSIAN DANCE) | 4 · DANCE OF THE REED FLUTES | 5 · WALTZ OF THE FLOWERS | 6 · DANCE OF THE SUGAR PLUM FAIRY

WHY I CHOSE IT

DRAW THE MUSIC Use shapes, lines and colors for the tempo, dynamics and mood.

WRITE TO A FRIEND Tell a friend about this ballet. Use at least 3 words from the listening toolkit (page 5).

Stars for my listening: ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆

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